

Pivot or persevere

Week 2, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- The Ries pivot taxonomy: seven named pivot types
- What makes a zoom-in pivot different from the others
- Time-boxed experiments: design before you build
- The shorts feed as a zoom-in pivot candidate
- Why the four-lever framework picks one lever at a time
- The fork decision memo: structure and required fields

The Ries pivot taxonomy

Seven named pivot types

Eric Ries (2011) named seven pivot types that cover almost every strategic fork a pre-PMF startup faces:

1. **Zoom-in:** a feature becomes the whole product
2. **Zoom-out:** the current product becomes a feature in a larger one
3. **Customer segment:** same problem, different customer
4. **Customer need:** same customer, different problem
5. **Platform:** from app to platform, or vice versa
6. **Business architecture:** high-margin low-volume vs low-margin high-volume
7. **Technology:** same positioning, different implementation

The taxonomy matters because each type has a different evidence requirement and a different build cost.

(Ries, 2011)

The zoom-in pivot in detail

A zoom-in pivot happens when one feature of an existing product is doing all the work and the rest is noise.

The feature-as-product becomes the new thesis. The remaining features either migrate to support it or are cut.

Evidence profile: the feature's engagement metrics (completion rate, return rate, share rate) exceed every other surface in the product by a meaningful margin.

(Ries, 2011; First Round Review, 2023)

The shorts feed as a zoom-in candidate

LangoBee's full product: reader, YouTube video viewer, and a short-form vertical feed.

The shorts feed in June 2026: 408 impressions, 101 completions, 13 real users, 1 share, 28% completion rate, 63% skip rate.

The question a zoom-in pivot asks: if you removed every other surface and shipped only the shorts feed, would the 13 users who came back be the seed of a product people love?

The answer is not yet known. The thesis has not been written. The time box has not been set.

(June 2026 snapshot)

Time-boxed experiments

What makes an experiment time-boxed

A time-boxed experiment has four required fields:

1. **Hypothesis:** a falsifiable claim about user behavior.
2. **Metric:** the one number that will confirm or deny the hypothesis.
3. **Kill threshold:** the number below which you stop and pivot.
4. **Decision date:** the calendar date at which you read the result and decide.

Without all four, the experiment cannot be killed. It runs forever, consuming runway.

(Duke, 2022; Ries, 2011)

The pre-mortem for a fork decision

Annie Duke (2022) introduces the pre-mortem as the mechanism that makes kill criteria stick. Before the experiment starts:

1. Imagine it is the decision date. The metric missed the kill threshold.
2. Write down every story you would tell yourself for why the result does not count.
3. Write a counter-story for each one.
4. Set the kill threshold at a level you would accept even given the best counter-story.

For LangoBee's fork: the pre-mortem question is "What would I tell myself if 0 trials start by July 15?" Write those stories before the experiment runs, not after.

(Duke, 2022)

The four-lever framework

First Round Review (2023) documents pre-PMF stagnation across Vanta, Plaid, Clay, and Lattice using a four-lever model:

- **Problem:** is the problem urgent and real for this person?
- **Persona:** is this the right customer for this problem?
- **Promise:** does the product promise match what they care about?
- **Product:** does the product deliver on the promise?

The finding across all four companies: recovery required a 200% adjustment on one lever, not incremental improvement across all four. Spreading effort across levers produces local optima, not escapes from stagnation.

(First Round Review, 2023)

Applying the four levers to LangoBee's fork

Problem: comprehensible-input learners lack a unified premium content surface. Persona: self-directed adult Spanish learners. Promise: the best native-content library at \$7.99/mo. Product lever: 17,440 texts shipped. Gap: promise-to-product conversion (no trials started).

Problem: comprehensible-input learners want short discovery without commitment. Persona: casual social-media learners. Promise: the most shareable Spanish learning

Library thesis

Shorts thesis

Each thesis is weak on a different lever. One experiment cannot test both.

The fork decision memo

Required fields in the memo

A fork decision memo is not a brainstorm or a preference statement. It is a structured document with required fields:

1. **The two hypotheses**, stated falsifiably (not "we will explore").
2. **The metric each hypothesis is judged on**, named and defined.
3. **The kill threshold for each**, stated as a number and a condition.
4. **The time box**, a specific calendar range.
5. **The decision date**, a specific calendar date.
6. **Who decides**, even if it is the founder alone.

Section this week: draft this memo for the library vs shorts fork.

"More often than not, if you're working on something that is not getting great traction, you're probably not a 10% adjustment away -- you're probably a 200% adjustment away."

First Round Review (2023)

The Pivot to Product-Market Fit

Take-aways

1. Ries named seven pivot types. Naming the type forces clarity about what is actually changing: the product, the customer, the business model, or the problem.
2. A zoom-in pivot treats one feature as the new whole product. It requires evidence that the feature's engagement exceeds the rest of the product.
3. Every time-boxed experiment needs a hypothesis, a metric, a kill threshold, and a decision date. Missing any one of these turns the experiment into open-ended building.
4. The four-lever framework picks the single most misaligned lever. LangoBee's two fork directions are each weak on different levers.
5. The fork decision memo is the section deliverable: two falsifiable hypotheses, explicit kill thresholds, a time box, and a decision date.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 2: Thesis discipline and the fork decision" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk02>
- **Section this week:** Write the fork decision memo (see section worksheet)
- **HW1:** Still in flight, due week 3
- **Week 3:** Activation and the broken-vacuum test: what LangoBee's 34-second median session tells you